

Dental Emergencies and Urgent Care

What to do if you have an urgent dental problem

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Sample content: Bright Smile Dental is a fictional practice. This document was written for a software demonstration and is not medical advice.

About this guide

This guide explains what to do if you have an urgent dental problem, how quickly you need to be seen, and where to get help when Bright Smile Dental is closed. It is general guidance only and does not replace advice from a dentist, NHS 111 or emergency services.

Bright Smile Dental's chat assistant cannot assess or diagnose an urgent problem. If you tell the chat assistant about a problem that may be urgent, it will direct you to the right help in this guide and give you the practice phone number.

When to call 999 or go to A&E

Some dental problems are medical emergencies. Call 999 or go straight to your nearest A&E department, not to the dentist, if you have:

- Swelling in your mouth, face or neck that is making it difficult to breathe, swallow or speak.
- Swelling that is spreading to your eye, so that the eye is closing, or spreading down your neck.
- Bleeding from the mouth that is heavy and does not stop after 20 minutes of firm pressure, especially if you feel faint.
- A serious injury to the face or jaw, especially with a head injury, loss of consciousness, double vision or vomiting.
- Swelling with a high temperature and feeling very unwell.

These signs can mean a spreading infection or serious injury that needs hospital treatment quickly.

How urgent is my dental problem?

How urgent	Examples	What to do
Emergency: get help now	Swelling affecting breathing, swallowing or the eye; bleeding that will not stop; serious face or jaw injury	Call 999 or go to A&E
Urgent: same day	Adult tooth knocked out; severe toothache not controlled by pain relief; facial swelling without breathing problems; broken tooth with severe pain; bleeding after an extraction that keeps restarting	Call Bright Smile Dental as soon as it opens, or NHS 111 if it is closed
Soon: within a few days	Dry socket after an extraction; lost filling or crown with some pain; chipped tooth with sensitivity; broken denture	Book the next available appointment
Routine	Lost filling or crown with no pain; small chip with no pain; mild sensitivity	Book a normal appointment

Urgent appointments at Bright Smile Dental

Bright Smile Dental keeps a small number of appointments free each weekday for patients with urgent problems. Urgent appointments are given by phone only, so that the practice team can ask about your symptoms. Call +44 20 7946 0123 from 9:00am.

Urgent appointments cannot be booked through the chat assistant, because the chat assistant cannot judge how urgent a problem is. Urgent same-day appointments are offered to registered and new patients.

Out-of-hours dental help

When Bright Smile Dental is closed, in the evenings, at weekends and on bank holidays:

- For an urgent dental problem, call NHS 111. NHS 111 can tell you where to get urgent dental care nearby.
- For a life-threatening emergency, call 999 or go to A&E.

The Bright Smile Dental phone line plays a recorded message with this information when the practice is closed.

Knocked-out adult tooth

A knocked-out adult tooth can sometimes be saved if it is put back into the socket quickly, ideally within an hour. Act fast and stay calm.

If an adult tooth is knocked out:

1. Find the tooth and pick it up by the crown, the white part you normally see. Do not touch the root.
2. If the tooth is dirty, rinse it briefly in milk or with a gentle stream of cold water for no more than ten seconds. Do not scrub it or wrap it in tissue.
3. If you can, push the tooth gently back into the socket, the right way round. Bite gently on a clean handkerchief to hold it in place.
4. If you cannot put it back, keep the tooth in a container of milk. An adult may instead keep the tooth inside their cheek, but do not do this for a child, who may swallow it.
5. Contact Bright Smile Dental or NHS 111 straight away and say that a tooth has been knocked out.

If the injury happened with a blow to the head, or the person has been knocked out, feels sick or has a headache, go to A&E first.

Knocked-out baby tooth

Never try to put a knocked-out baby tooth back in. Putting it back can damage the adult tooth developing underneath. Stop any bleeding by pressing on a clean cloth, and contact Bright Smile Dental so that the dentist can check the child's mouth.

Broken or chipped tooth

If a tooth is broken or chipped:

- Rinse your mouth gently with warm water.
- If you can find the broken piece, keep it in milk and bring it to the appointment, as it can sometimes be bonded back on.
- Cover any sharp edge with sugar-free chewing gum or dental wax from a pharmacy to protect your tongue and cheek.
- Avoid chewing on the broken tooth and avoid very hot or cold food.

A broken tooth with severe pain, or where you can see a pink or red spot in the centre, needs to be seen the same day. A small chip with no pain can wait for a routine appointment.

Severe toothache

Severe toothache is often caused by decay or infection reaching the nerve of the tooth. While you wait to be seen:

- Take over-the-counter pain relief, following the packet instructions. Ask a pharmacist if you are not sure what is suitable for you.
- Avoid very hot, cold or sweet food on that side.
- Sleep with your head slightly raised.
- Do not put pain relief tablets against the gum or tooth. This can burn the gum.

Contact Bright Smile Dental the same day if toothache is severe or keeps you awake. If the toothache comes with swelling of the face, a high temperature, or difficulty swallowing, follow the emergency advice at the start of this guide.

Dental abscess and facial swelling

A dental abscess is a collection of pus caused by a bacterial infection, usually at the root of a tooth or in the gum. Signs of an abscess include a throbbing pain, a tooth that is very tender to touch, a swelling on the gum, a bad taste, swelling of the face and a high temperature.

A dental abscess does not go away on its own and needs treatment from a dentist, even if the pain stops. Contact Bright Smile Dental the same day. If swelling affects your breathing, swallowing or your eye, call 999 or go to A&E immediately.

Lost filling or crown

If a filling falls out, the tooth may be sensitive, but this is not usually an emergency. Keep the area clean and book an appointment within a few days. A temporary filling kit from a pharmacy can protect the tooth until then.

If a crown comes off, keep it safe and bring it to your appointment, as it can often be cemented back on. Do not use household glue to stick a crown back on. If a lost crown or filling is causing severe pain, ask for an urgent appointment.

Problems after treatment at Bright Smile Dental

If you have a problem after treatment at Bright Smile Dental, such as bleeding after an extraction, signs of dry socket, or a high filling, see the Aftercare Instructions document first, then contact the practice. Problems after treatment are always seen as a priority.